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Problem Statement ID: SIH26136

Problem Statement Title: Startup Friendly Public Procurement
Mechanism that Enables Government Departments to Identify, Pilot, Procure, and Scale Innovative Solutions from Eligible Startups

Organization: Government of Maharashtra

Theme: Miscellaneous

PS Category: Software

Team ID: 187011

Team Name: Six Hats

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Idea: Problem → Pilot → Scale

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The gap: Departments can't easily find, trial, or buy from capable startups. Turnover/experience cutoffs shut them out, and tendering is slow and paper-heavy.

Polaris: an AI-powered platform guiding departments through the full startup procurement lifecycle

DISCOVER

1. Problem Formulation
AI turns a raw need into a clear, outcome-based brief

2. Matching & Shortlisting
Startups ranked on capability signals, not just turnover

PILOT

3. Contract & Escrow
Milestone payment plan created and locked

4. Pilot Execution
Startup delivers; funds release per approved milestone

5. Independent Validation
Outside auditor certifies the completed pilot

SCALE

6. Public Solutions Library
Certified solutions any department can adopt directly

7. Admin Oversight
Central admin monitors the pipeline, approves officials

WHAT MAKES POLARIS DIFFERENT

AI Problem-Statement Generator
Converts a department's raw need into a structured, outcome-based statement.

AI Startup Matching + Eligibility Scoring
Ranks startups on alternate capability signals, removing rigid turnover and experience cutoffs.

Milestone Payments, Human Sign-off
Escrow-backed funds release per milestone; AI never approves a payment alone.

Departments: faster, lower-risk pilots **Startups:** fair access, predictable payments **Government:** transparency + reusable solutions

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Technical Approach

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Technologies to be used

Frontend
Next.js + Tailwind CSS

Backend & Database
Supabase (Postgres, Auth, Storage)

Hosting
Vercel

AI Layer
Claude/GPT API — problem generation, startup matching, eligibility scoring

Dev approach
AI-assisted development for rapid prototyping

Methodology and process for implementation

1. Department submits raw problem description via **web portal**
2. AI Problem Generator converts it into a **structured, outcome-based statement**
3. AI Matching Engine (NLP-based similarity) **ranks relevant startups** from database
4. AI Eligibility Scoring evaluates startups on **alternate signals**, not just turnover/experience
5. Shortlisted startups move to **pilot design → milestone-based contract → performance tracking**
6. Independent **validation checkpoint** before **scale-up decision** across departments

Prototype

Video
website

Department Portal 01
input: problem description

AI Problem Generator 02
LLM-based

AI Matching Engine 03
NLP similarity search

AI Eligibility Scoring 04
ML-based scoring

Pilot & Milestone Tracker 05
database

Scale-up Dashboard 06
outcome

Tech Stack

Next.js | Tailwind | Supabase | Claude/GPT | Vercel

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Feasibility And Viability

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Analysis of the feasibility

5 — Working prototype

Built and tested end-to-end: 5 working user roles — department, startup, validator, admin, pending approval

END-TO-END TESTED

Ready-made tech stack

Uses Supabase and Google Gemini API — no custom AI models or infra built from scratch

NO CUSTOM AI / INFRA

Policy-backed design

Grounded in real policy — structured around GFR Rule 149 for scale-up exemption

GFR RULE 149

Potential challenges and risks	Strategies for overcoming these challenges
AI eligibility scoring could introduce bias if trained on limited data	1 — Every fund release requires human sign-off — AI never approves payments alone
Departments may resist replacing familiar tendering with a new system	2 — Start with phased rollout in 1–2 departments before wider adoption
Full-scale real-world testing beyond demo/pilot stage still needed (limited real-world data)	3 — Use synthetic data for demo now, partner with a real department post-hackathon
Legal/IP clause standardization	4 — Modular customizable templates

ROLLOUT PATH

Demo on synthetic data
Prove the full workflow with zero real-data risk

Pilot in 1–2 departments
Validate with real users in live conditions

Wider adoption
Scale across departments with reusable solutions

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IMPACT AND BENEFITS

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IMPACT ON TARGET AUDIENCE

Departments
Faster access to vetted innovation; pilot-first buying lowers risk and cuts tender delays.

Startups
No turnover or experience barrier; milestone payments give steady cash flow.

Citizens
Faster, better-quality public services through a shorter path from problem to deployment.

Scalable across departments and districts
One verified pilot record, reused across departments, districts and states.



BENEFITS

Social
Stronger startup ecosystem and govt–startup trust for first-time founders.

Economic
Less wasted procurement spend; new revenue and jobs for startups.

Environmental
Faster adoption of proven cleantech and sustainable solutions.

Governance
Transparent, auditable pilots with independent evaluators cut corruption risk.

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RESEARCH AND REFERENCES

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1 PROCUREMENT PORTAL

GeM (Government e-Marketplace)

gem.gov.in

National public procurement portal: shows how startups list offerings and sell directly to government buyers.

2 FUNDING

Startup India Seed Fund Scheme

seedfund.startupindia.gov.in

Funds proof of concept, prototyping and market entry for early-stage startups.

3 POLICY

Public Procurement Policy for Micro and Small Enterprises (MSE)

Ministry OF MSME

Reserves a share of government purchases for micro and small enterprises, opening doors for new vendors.

4 FRAMEWORK

Startup India Action Plan

startupindia.gov.in

National framework for simpler compliance, easier funding access and incentives for startups.

5 GLOBAL PRECEDENT

"Startup in Residence" Innovation Procurement Model

https://startupinresidence.com/

Agencies post real public challenges and startups co-develop solutions: a model for innovation procurement.

6 STATE POLICY

Maharashtra Startup, Entrepreneurship and Innovation Policy 2025

Govt. of Maharashtra · MSINS

State-level support for incubation, funding and scale-up, implemented by Maharashtra State Innovation Society.

GitHub: Github Link

Procurement · Funding · Policy · Global precedent · State ecosystem